having them perform a piece from *Petrushka* as he entered the auditorium. Astonished by their skill, he remarked that he was very pleased with the orchestra's performance, even with fewer rehearsals than anticipated."

Mehta will lead the orchestra in Beethoven's *Leonore Overture No. 3*, Chopin's *Piano Concerto No. 2* featuring Alexander Gadjiev as the soloist, Dvořák's *Symphony No. 7*, Mahler's *Symphony No. 5* and Haydn's *Symphony No. 104 "London"*. The Opera Gala will feature excerpts from *Carmen* and *La Traviata*, with international vocal talents such as Roberta Mantegna, Olesya Petrova, Luciano Ganci and George Petean. The Living Voices-Mumbai choir and the Singing Tree Choir of the Mehli Mehta Music Foundation will also lend their voices to this grand celebration of music.

This season also welcomes Sir Mark Elder, making his SOI debut with a stirring programme that includes Beethoven's *Eroica* Symphony and Schumann's *Overture, Scherzo and Finale*. Suntook emphasises Elder's significance: "This season, we are privileged to have Sir Mark Elder, an exceptional conductor who is highly regarded across the globe. His involvement underscores the calibre of artistry the SOI aspires to present."

The SOI now has a growing presence of Indian musicians. It is also planning projects that blend cultures and art forms

Suntook reveals the thought behind the season's programming: "Zubin and I curated the entire season. It's a blend of symphonies, operatic works and concertos designed to appeal to a diverse audience. While we occasionally differ in opinion, such as in the choice of singers, our collaborative spirit ensures a cohesive programme."

The SOI is witnessing a growing presence of Indian musicians in its ensemble. Suntook expressed pride in this development: "It's heartening to see more Indian musicians joining the orchestra. Their growth and integration into the SOI are a testament to the rising appreciation and talent for western classical music within the country."

Looking beyond this season, the SOI is ambitiously planning projects that blend cultures and art forms. Suntook highlighted one such vision: "A unique aspiration we are keen to develop is the tasteful and artistic blending of Indian classical music and Indian dance forms with the SOI. This synthesis represents a unique form of music-making."

Suntook acknowledges the unwavering support of the orchestra's benefactors: "These ambitious projects would not be possible without the unwavering support of our fundraising champions and the contributions of esteemed benefactors." Organisations like the Tata Group and leading financial institutions have played a crucial role in enabling the SOI to bring these visions to life. ■

–Nikhil Sardana

(See www.soimumbai.com for programme details)

MUSIC

SPRING IN THEIR SETS

The upcoming **Spring 2025 Season** of the Symphony Orchestra of India at NCPA, Mumbai—headlined by Maestro Zubin Mehta and Sir Mark Elder—promises a host of international performers



MASTER BATON WIELDERS
Far left, Zubin Mehta conducts the SOI; left, conductor Sir Mark Elder